and India, and then also China, “moved to the front line of rule-making” and loosely coordinated to increase their bargaining power.[102] Brazil and India had agitated for developing countries’ interests in multilateral trade since the creation of the General Agreement on Tariffs and Trade (GATT). However, for the first time since the expansion of their share of world trade in the 1990s and 2000s, together with China, they faced the incumbent powers (grouped in the traditional “Quad” of the United States, European Union, Canada, and Japan) as formidable challengers representing the developing world.[103] In 2003, India, Brazil, and South Africa created the IBSA Dialogue Forum on South-South Cooperation (IBSA), jointly providing the vision and leadership core for the developing nations’ trade G20, whose principled resistance to the U.S. “deep integration” agenda played an important role in the eventual failure of the WTO Doha Round of trade liberalization negotiations. Not only were these emerging powers coalescing in ways that demonstrated learning and adaptation, as expected by the competitive socialization process in international relations, they also were acquiring the necessary technical and diplomatic skills to bolster their bargaining effectiveness.[104]

Also notable for the coevolution of the BRICS is that the informal BIC (Brazil, India, China) trade coalition, in its different configurations, did not use its greater bargaining power to pursue solely distributive interests, but also to varying degrees “a proactive agenda-moving one,” led by Brazil, to support the system.[105] As a result, new and diverse groups mixing incumbent and rising powers have replaced the old Quad.[106] But seeking to restore their leverage, the developed countries shifted to plurilateral trade agreements, such as the TPP during the Obama administration, and similar exclusionary approaches, including behind-the-border measures, seeking venues in which the United States would again possess greater leverage or bargaining power.

Thus, it is now evident that both status quo and rising powers have rational incentives to create clubs like “G groups” as a means to search for common focal points, develop unified positions, and clandestinely coordinate in the framing and pushing of policies that reflect their interests. According to the Russian Deputy Foreign Minister and BRICS Sherpa Sergei Ryabkov, the BRICS is a club that operates on consensus, where “no one imposes anything on anybody else.” At the same time, he stressed that